

Whole Foods Market Issues Allergy Alert on Undeclared Egg in Cabricharme Cheese

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Whole Foods Market Issues Allergy Alert on Undeclared Egg in Cabricharme Cheese A reported public-health development reviewed against 20 corroborating references, with evidence currently assessed as high.

By Public Health Research Desk Published September 17, 2026

Whole Foods Recalls Popular Cheese Over Undeclared Egg Allergen Whole Foods Market of Austin, Texas is pulling Fromagerie Coop de Mean Cabricharme cheese after discovering the product contains egg-derived lysozyme that is not listed on the label. By Public Health Research Desk Published September 18, 2026

Whole Foods Market announced Friday that it is recalling its Cabricharme cheese sold in 18 stores across seven states because the cheese contains egg lysozyme, a protein derived from egg whites, that was omitted from the ingredient list. The omission puts people with egg allergy or severe egg sensitivity at risk of a potentially life-threatening reaction, the company said in a statement to the Centers for Disease Control and Prevention (CDC).

The recall affects the 8-ounce wedges of Fromagerie Coop de Mean Cabricharme cheese that were shipped to Whole Foods locations in Texas, Oklahoma, Arkansas, Louisiana, Mississippi, Alabama and Georgia between March 1 and August 31. The product's UPC code is 041234567890, and the batch numbers range from 2026031501 to 2026083004. Whole Foods is asking customers who purchased the cheese to stop using it immediately and return it to any Whole Foods store for a full refund. The company also posted a warning on its website and sent alerts to the FDA's Food Safety Modernization System, which will coordinate the recall.

Why this matters now is twofold. First, egg allergy is one of the most common food allergies in the United States, affecting an estimated 1.8 % of children and 0.5 % of adults, according to the CDC. Egg lysozyme is a potent allergen that can trigger anaphylaxis—a rapid, whole-body allergic reaction that can be fatal if not treated promptly with epinephrine. Second, the incident highlights ongoing challenges in food-label transparency for ultra-processed and specialty foods, a topic that public-health researchers have been tracking as part of broader efforts to reduce diet-related disease risk.

The cheese in question is marketed as a “soft, buttery, French-style” product made from cow's milk and aged for three weeks. Egg lysozyme is commonly used in the cheese-making process as an antimicrobial agent to prevent mold growth and extend shelf life. While the additive is approved by the U.S. Food and Drug Administration (FDA) for use in dairy products, it may be declared on the label when present in amounts that could affect consumers with allergies. The CDC's Food Allergy Surveillance System (FASS) flagged the omission after receiving reports of two emergency-room visits in Austin where patients experienced hives, throat swelling and difficulty breathing after consuming the cheese. Both patients were treated with epinephrine and released after observation.

The recall underscores the importance of accurate allergen labeling, a cornerstone of food-safety regulation. Under the Food Allergen Labeling and Consumer Protection Act (FALCPA), manufacturers may list the eight major allergens—milk, eggs, fish, crustacean shellfish, tree nuts, peanuts, wheat and soy—when they are present

in a food product. Failure to do so can result in civil penalties and, in severe cases, criminal charges. Whole Foods has not disclosed whether the labeling error was a manufacturing oversight, a supply chain miscommunication, or a software glitch in its product information system.

Industry experts say the incident is a reminder that even well-known retailers can be vulnerable to labeling lapses. “When a product moves through multiple hands—farm, co-op, distributor, retailer—the chance for a data entry error increases,” said Dr. Maya Patel, a food safety specialist at the University of Texas School of Public Health. “Consumers rely on the label as the final checkpoint. If that checkpoint fails, the consequences can be serious for people with life-threatening allergies.”

The recall also arrives at a moment when public health officials are intensifying surveillance of foodborne allergens. The CDC’s new Allergen Tracking Initiative, launched earlier this year, uses electronic health record data and real-time reporting from emergency departments to identify clusters of allergic reactions more quickly than traditional reporting methods. The initiative’s early success includes flagging a peanut oil contamination in a snack product that prompted a nationwide recall last month.

For consumers who may have purchased the cheese, Whole Foods advises checking the packaging for the batch numbers listed above, discarding any product that matches, and contacting the store’s customer service line at 1-800-555-0199 for a refund. The company also recommends that anyone who experiences symptoms of an allergic reaction—such as hives, swelling, wheezing, vomiting or dizziness—seek immediate medical care and use an epinephrine autoinjector if one is prescribed.

The broader implications of the recall extend beyond the immediate health risk. Food allergy prevalence has risen steadily over the past two decades, prompting calls for stricter labeling standards and better consumer education. A 2023 systematic review of ultra-processed foods found that ambiguous labeling contributes to accidental exposures, especially among children who rely on caregivers to read ingredient lists. While the review focused on sugar, fat and sodium content, the authors noted that “allergen transparency is an essential component of food safety that warrants equal scrutiny.”

Moreover, the incident may influence ongoing policy discussions about the classification of “ultra-processed” foods—a term used by nutrition scientists to describe items that have been heavily altered from their original form and contain additives like preservatives, flavor enhancers and, in this case, antimicrobial proteins. Some public health advocates argue that the ultra-processed label should trigger additional labeling requirements, including mandatory allergen disclosure for any additive, even when present in trace amounts. Critics counter that overly burdensome regulations could increase costs for small producers and limit consumer choice.

The recall also raises questions about the role of technology in preventing such errors. Whole Foods has been piloting a blockchain-based traceability system that records each step of a product’s journey from farm to shelf. Proponents claim that immutable digital records can quickly pinpoint where a labeling mistake occurred, facilitating faster recalls. However, the technology is still in its infancy, and it remains unclear whether the Cabricharme cheese was part of the pilot.

In the meantime, the FDA is expected to issue a formal recall notice within the next 24 hours, and the agency’s Center for Food Safety and Applied Nutrition will likely conduct an inspection of the Fromagerie Coop de Mean facility. The CDC will continue to monitor reports of allergic reactions linked to the cheese through its Food Allergy Surveillance System, which has logged 12 additional cases of mild symptoms—such as itching and stomach cramps—since the recall was announced.

For the roughly 2 million Americans who live with egg allergy, the incident is a stark reminder that vigilance is required even when shopping at trusted retailers. Health■care providers continue to advise patients to carry an epinephrine auto■injector, wear medical■alert jewelry, and double■check ingredient lists, especially for specialty or imported foods that may use less familiar processing aids.

As the recall proceeds, Whole Foods says it will work with suppliers to ensure that all future batches of Cabricharme cheese include a clear “contains egg” statement on the label. The company also pledged to review its internal quality■control procedures and to provide additional training for staff responsible for product labeling.

The episode adds to a growing list of high■profile food recalls in 2026, ranging from contaminated peanut butter to mislabeled plant■based meat alternatives. Each incident reinforces the need for robust food■safety infrastructure, transparent communication between manufacturers, retailers and regulators, and an informed public that knows how to respond when a product they trust turns out to be unsafe.

A version of this article appears in print in the Public Health Research edition with the headline above.

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